nationalist leaders. The act, however, contained a provision for the appointment of a commission after ten years to investigate, and report upon, the progress of constitutional reforms, with a view to making further reforms, but such a review was not due until 1929. However, at home in the United Kingdom, the Conservative government of Stanley Baldwin was about to lose the upcoming elections to the Labour Party. This was headed by Clement Attlee. It therefore acted early in 1927 to appoint 'The Indian Statutory Commission', more popularly known as the 'Simon Commission', headed by the distinguished liberal lawyer, Sir John Allsebrook Simon. Its purpose was to delay and forestall further constitutional reform. Consisting of seven British MPs, one of whom was Clement Attlee, it arrived in British India in 1928. It was almost immediately met by stormy opposition by Indian nationalist leaders, when it arrived in Bombay on 3 February 1928.

The Simon Commission did not contain a single Indian member, though it was to determine the future of India. The Indian National Congress boycotted it and Muhammed Ali Jinnah led a faction of the Muslim League against it. On 30 October 1928, when the commission arrived in Lahore, it was met by a demonstration led by the Indian nationalist leader, Lala Lajpat Rai, waving black flags, who had already in February 1928 moved a resolution in the Punjab Legislative Assembly against the commission. The local police, in an effort to make way for the commission, began beating the protesters. Lala Lajpat Rai suffered head injuries and died two weeks later, and it was his death that Bhagat Singh set out to avenge when he mistakenly assassinated J.P. Saunders instead of his superior, J.A. Scott, the superintendent of police in charge of controlling the crowd in Lahore at the time of the arrival of the Simon Commission.

The Simon Commission went on to publish a two-volume report in May 1930 proposing provincial autonomy for India but rejecting central parliamentary responsibility in Delhi, through a federated arrangement, whereby the British Crown would retain direct contact with the Indian states. In fact, it sowed the seeds for the eventual partition of India. This is why when the Government of India Act 1935 was passed, its call for